Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list “silver = this”, and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made up of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we have lived through ourselves**.

From the body

Silver is the colour of **the moon, water and mist**. The eye catches it by the reflection that changes when you move. That helps explain why silver can have a relationship to coolness and to a feeling of distance.

From culture

In most of the world silver is linked with **the moon, purity and second place**. Coins, cutlery, medals, mirrors. At the same time it can mean betrayal and cold distance. In the chapter on cultures we will look at this in more detail.

From what you have lived

Grandmother's spoons, a silver chain from a godmother, a first silver ring. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same silver** and one feels calm, the other distance.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is actually “silver” and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does silver connect with first for me and where do I know that from?**

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Stories

Silver has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where begins what people make of it.

The silver bullet

In folklore silver is linked with protection against supernatural beings. Some authors connect the silver bullet against werewolves with the Beast of Gévaudan, which the hunter Jean Chastel was supposed to have killed in **1767**. According to one review, the story of silver bullets made from melted-down medals with the Virgin Mary is a distortion mainly from Henri Pourrat's novel of 1946. Silver as the standard weapon against werewolves was made only by the 1941 film The Wolf Man.

Today the phrase silver bullet means a simple solution to a hard problem. Silver here is not a metal. It is **a story about how much we want a simple recipe**.

The mirror

Glass mirrors appear from the first century and for centuries were small and uneven. In the Renaissance a mirror of tin and mercury arose, which Venice long held. In **1835** the German chemist Justus von Liebig developed a procedure in which a thin layer of silver is chemically applied to glass. The method made it possible to produce mirrors on a large scale.

Silver in a mirror does not reflect colour but light. It seemingly disappears itself and shows you. Silver is **a metal that hides in order to show something else**.

Photography from silver

In **1839** the daguerreotype was publicly announced. A silvered copper plate was polished to a mirror, exposed to iodine vapours and after exposure the image was developed with mercury vapours. The result is a unique image on a mirror surface, which looks like a positive or a negative depending on the angle of view.

For a long time afterwards photography rested on the sensitivity of silver halides. Silver thus carries light and memory at once. Silver here is not coldness. It is **a place where light was written down**.

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